THE BATTLE OF IDEOLOGIES

As important for the Congress is the message Rahul is conveying. That includes his signature slogan—"*Nafrat ke bazaar mein mohabbat ki dukaan khol raha hoon* (am setting up a shop of love in the marketplace of hatred)." With this underpinning, Rahul on his yatra set about taking Modi, the BJP and their mentor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) to task, focusing on a trinity of issues. The first being the economic front, where Rahul has concentrated on exposing income inequalities, the lack of jobs, price rise and crony capitalism; the second highlighting social issues, including the BJP and RSS using religion, caste and even people's attire to polarise the country; and the third relating to political authoritarianism, which includes subjugating the judiciary and misusing enforcement agencies to settle scores with rivals. Rahul even specified to Jairam the ratio of focus for each issue raised during the yatra: 50 per cent for the economy, 30 per cent for social issues and 20 per cent for political ones.

From the very beginning, Rahul has been clear that BJY is not an "election *jeetne ki yatra*" or a "*berozgaari hatane ki yatra*", as an aide put it, but one about winning the battle of two opposing ideologies. According to Rahul, the one espoused by the BJP and RSS uses hate, coercion and division to enforce their writ across the country even while pushing for uniformity of religion and language. The ideology he champions, on the other hand, celebrates India's diversity, with unity, harmony and equity intrinsic to the country's ancient culture. Similar to the "kinder, gentler nation" that George Bush Sr advocated for the USA when he campaigned for his presidency.

Those who know him well say that this ideology is in tune with Rahul's personality. He has always been uncomfortable with the hurly-burly of day-to-day politics or having to play conflict manager, something that most political leaders are adept at doing. Rahul, in fact, felt that the Congress had become an election machine seeking power for power's sake, leaving the battleground of ideas and ideologies for the BJP and RSS to occupy. For him, it was important that the Congress sharpen its ideological spurs by abandoning its position of strategic ambiguity on key issues confronting the country and taking a stand. The half a dozen short-duration yatras Rahul had undertaken in the past decade, mainly for farmers' rights and relief, had left him with the desire to embark on a national yatra that would connect him directly with the masses. In this, says Jairam, he seems to have been inspired by the same verse of French philosopher Albert Camus as Nelson Mandela. "Don't walk in front of me. I may not follow. Don't walk behind me. I may not lead. Walk beside me and just be my friend."

Yogendra Yadav, a former psephologist and founder of Swaraj India who joined the yatra, believes that "if this yatra had not taken place, it would have been a climate of gloom, helplessness, of anti-Modi and anti-BJP energies being completely scattered, ideological opposition to this regime being completely fragmented". Broadly, he adds, "the yatra has done three things. First, it has re-energised the Congress organisation and workers in every sphere. Second, anti-BJP forces in civil society, who are opposed to the BJP's Hindutva ideology, have started taking the Congress seriously again. Third, Rahul Gandhi's personal image has undergone a dramatic change. He is no more seen as an entitled, arrogant person, with no understanding of India." Rahul Verma, a fellow at the Centre for Policy Research (CPR) and visiting assistant professor in the Department of

POST-INDEPENDENCE YATRAS OF SIGNIFICANCE

1983

Janata Party president **Chandra Shekhar** embarked on a 4,260 km, 190-day-long Bharat Yatra from Kanyakumari to Rajghat to highlight the alleged misrule of Indira Gandhi





PRASHANT PANJIAR

1990

Lal Krishna Advani launched the Ram Rath Yatra from Somnath to Ayodhya to consolidate support for the Ram temple

1991-92

Murli Manohar Joshi, then BJP president, went on a 46-day Ekta Yatra from Kanyakumari to Srinagar for national unity

1997

BJP leaders took out a Swarna Jayanti Rath Yatra to celebrate 50 years of India's Independence. Travelling 15,000+ km, the yatra covered 21 states over 59 days



SHARAD SAXENA